



Guardian call: "India should set up a national college for goalkeepers as soon as possible" — Panagiotis Dilmperis, head coach of Punjab FC.

PUNJAB FC MEDIA

Swede Mikael Stahre stepping in as the new coach, Peprah is facing considerable pressure as the new ISL season begins.

The saviour

But Peprah is handling the pressure well, proving to be Kerala Blasters' saviour with a late winner in its 2-1 victory over East Bengal FC, securing its first win of the season. In a dramatic twist, his goal came just 13 minutes after he was subbed in, stealing the spotlight from East Bengal's Diamantakos.

The Blasters had lost its season opener 1-2 to Punjab FC, conceding two late goals. However, head coach Stahre made smart late substitutions for the next match against the Red and Gold.

"The reason we won is not just because of a strong starting lineup,

but also because of a good ending lineup," said Stahre after the victory.

"In the ISL, we see a lot of late goals every single week, even every single day. People talk about the starting lineup, but it's also crucial who is on the field in the final minutes — to control the game, chase a goal, or whatever the situation calls for. Today, we were clearly the stronger team over the 90 minutes against a good opponent."

Urgently needed: Goalkeeping school

While Stahre spoke confidently after Blasters' win, Punjab FC head coach Panagiotis Dilmperis may have wanted to offer some advice to East Bengal FC goalkeeper Prabhsukhan

Gill, who had a tough time when Peprah scored that stunning goal.

A former goalkeeper himself, Dilmperis strongly believes that India should establish a full-fledged goalkeeping school. "India should set up a national college for goalkeepers as soon as possible," said the Greek coach, who played as a professional goalkeeper for 17 years before moving into coaching. "A school with goalkeeping coaches and teachers would develop goalkeepers from youth level to the professional ranks."

Dilmperis pointed to his own country's example: "In Greece, they started a goalkeeping school in 2015, and I studied there. Italy, Germany, Serbia, and South America all have similar programmes. India needs something like this. It's very necessary."

He went on to explain the importance of specialised training for goalkeepers: "Goalkeeping is a unique position, which is why they wear a different jersey. I love the position; everyone knows that. I work closely with my goalkeeping coach, Manish Timsina, who is highly professional and knowledgeable."

Dilmperis, whose Punjab FC started the season strong with two consecutive wins, added, "We focus on teaching the tactics specific to the position, and I think the players are really responding to it."

Stan Rayan

'Slaps' that shape fortunes

NorthEast United FC's journey in the Indian Super League has chronicled disjointed performances in the first decade of the country's top football contest. The team, which by its nomenclature represents the most productive region of footballing talent in the country, has struggled for consistency, frequently changing

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